

Wanalume wali pano ku Harare wakopa koci?
Wali kukoma mzungu kuwaleka ndiko.

maize into flour:

What is the Malawian woman's attitude toward labor migration? The Labour Department Report stated, "Migration is unjust to the women in every way. However, the songs of the women reveal a less dogmatic attitude toward the stability of their menfolk's travels. Tumbuka women sing this song while pounding maize into flour:

Since most migrant analysts agree that the major motive behind Malawian emigration is economic, encouraging the planting of cash crops must be the inducement for men to remain at home. Africans have always grown cotton and tobacco in Malawi; smallholder tea planters and cattle-feeding stations are being established in the southern portion of the country. But bad weather, certain transportation, and the vicissitudes of international commodity markets make economic life uncertain for Malawian farmers. Fluctuations in these conditions are reflected in the number of emigrants. The 1952 Nyasaland Labourment Report stated that 150,000 men were abroad, 2,000 more than the 1951 figure and attributed the increase partially to a poor African tobacco crop. But, as Ronald E. Gregson (1969) has pointed out, there may be a regression in agricultural techniques when large numbers of migrants return home. When a plentiful supply of male labor became available in the Henga Valley, slash-and-burn methods replaced crop rotation, a system which made better use of the land and which the women employed when working the fields alone.

According to the Travers Lacey Report, the division of labor practiced most Malawian communities is as follows: women draw water, gather firewood, do everything connected with food preparations. Cassava, the Tonga staple, is easily cultivated crop grown primarily by women, and undoubtedly this was a factor in allowing such a high percentage of Tonga men to remain abroad. Both men and women weed and harvest the fields. Men alone clear land, erect and repair homes and granaries, and built kraals. The cultivation of cash crops is men's work as well.

The number of males who could be away from home at any one time without causing undue distress to village life has been the subject of diverse estimates. Van Velsen figured that a phenomenal 60 to 75 per cent of Tonga adult males were absent, but stated that there were no serious signs of disorganization in the society (1960, p. 277). A Belgian Congo commission reported that not more than 5 per cent of the men could be lost for long periods without adversely affecting local life (Nyasaland 1936, p. 36). F. E. Sanderson has declared that a 10 per cent absentee rate resulted in food shortages, immorality, disease, and the down of social fabric (1960, p. 133). Economist William Barber's opinion is that a subsistence agricultural system will not be harmed until 50 per cent of adult bodied men are missing (1961, p. 216). Watson felt that the Mambwe economy would be hurt if there were more than two women per man in each village (1958, p. 3). Increasing government direction of the agricultural sector of the economy and growing control over emigration are making this argument less urgent, but the able percentage of absent men seems to depend significantly on the traditional agricultural system employed by each group.

the husband was away, his wife lived under the protection of her parents. areas with a large number of missing men, an intolerable burden would fall old people.